The Bag at the Door

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 2, Episode 1

Morning slipped through the open door of the Treasure Tree. Yesterday’s damp leaves glittered outside. Inside, your finished adventure stood on the shelf: The Map Pieces. The whole map rested safely in its folio, beside the moonstone. Nothing was missing today.

“We found a library,” Lark declared delightedly. “Now we need readers!”

On the packing shelf lay three fresh invitations. Lark read their destinations aloud: Reed Hut, the Mill, and Fern Lodge. Nib dropped one into each of his new courier bag’s three pockets.

“Three deliveries,” Nib announced grandly. “One dependable mouse.”

He ducked under the strap. The bag settled with a soft thump. It was rather wider than the dependable mouse.

Lark brought two closed folios down from the shelf. They looked almost alike. One held the map; the other held your folded mat. Each had its own little label.

“Let’s take the map,” Lark suggested warmly. “Which label says map?”

With the map tucked safely into the bag, Nib marched toward the door. His feet made determined little pats across the boards. The bottom of the bag passed through. The middle passed through. Then the strap stopped dead.

“I have arrived,” Nib declared.

He glanced back at the packing shelf.

“At a very nearby destination,” Nib added doubtfully.

A loose loop had caught beneath the brass latch. The door was wide enough. The bag was wide enough. The strap had simply found the one place it could not pass.

Nib gave a small tug. The latch pressed a dent into the cloth.

“Don’t drag it,” Lark urged gently. “We’ll rub a hole in our delivery bag.”

You helped set the bag on the dry floor. Lark lifted the three invitations out, one by one, and laid them safely on the packing shelf. Nobody had received a delivery yet.

Nib drooped beside the doorway.

“A splendid bag,” Nib murmured sadly.

“A rather grabby latch,” Lark replied thoughtfully. “We need something soft between the brass and the strap.”

The shelf had two little cupboards. Their contents were hidden behind wooden doors. Lark drew a round shape, then a tall line beside it, on a small slate. A lowercase d.

“Listen to the beginning of dip,” Lark invited softly. “A quick little sound. Your tongue touches just behind your top teeth, then lets go.”

Nib tried it once. A tiny puff disturbed a speck of dust.

“A small sound for a difficult door,” Nib observed hopefully.

Lark set three letters in a row: p, a, d.

“Here are two sounds we know and our new one,” Lark explained patiently. “We can join them: pad. A soft pad can protect the strap. Slide with me, then say the whole word if you like.”

Nib leaned toward the cupboard nearest him. Then he paused. Both labels began with p. Both had a in the middle. That would not tell him which cupboard held the pad.

“I nearly picked the first one,” Nib admitted sheepishly.

“The last sound matters too,” Lark reminded him gently. “Find pad on the shelf.”

The cupboard opened. Inside lay a folded felt pad, just the right size. You carried it to the doorway. Its soft cloth wrapped around the sharp lower edge of the latch, leaving the handle clear.

Nib touched the strap. No new scrape. No deep dent.

“A padded problem,” Nib announced proudly.

“A protected strap,” Lark corrected him with a chuckle. “The loop is still caught underneath. We’ll need to do different jobs together.”

Lark fluttered up to lift the latch. Nib lowered the bag until its base rested on the floor. That made the strap slack. A clear opening appeared above the loose loop.

“I’ll hold this up,” Lark called steadily.

“I’ll keep the bag down,” Nib answered determinedly.

The loose strap rested within reach. You could guide it through the opening while your friends held their places. Nobody needed to tug.

“Bring the strap through the gap,” Lark urged encouragingly. “We’ll hold it for you.”

The loop slipped clear. Lark lowered the latch only after the cloth was free. Nib took one careful step backward. The bag came with him.

“It did!” Nib exclaimed delightedly. “It did go through!”

He examined the strap from end to end. The pad had kept it from tearing. Lark folded the pad around the strap’s worn spot and fastened its small cloth tie. It could travel with the bag now.

“We didn’t need a bigger door,” Lark remarked thoughtfully.

“Or a smaller mouse,” Nib added with relief. “Excellent news for the mouse.”

The three invitations still waited on the dry shelf. Lark read their destinations again and pointed to the matching pictures on the bag’s pockets: a reed-roofed hut, the Mill wheel, and Fern Lodge’s fern. You did not need to read those names yourself.

Nib held the pockets open, one at a time. Lark kept the bag steady. There was a separate place for every invitation.

“Three invitations,” Lark counted calmly. “Three pockets. Put each picture with its matching pocket, and we’ll check them together.”

One invitation in each pocket. Three invitations altogether. The map and route book lay in the main compartment, away from the damp patch on Nib’s scarf.

Lark opened a fresh journal. She drew the caught strap, the pad, and three friends doing three useful jobs. Nib added a very large doorway and a very small dent.

Beside the drawing, Lark fastened a little wooden tag from the packing shelf. She had written d on it.

“Our doorway tag,” Lark explained warmly. “For the first page of our delivery adventure.”

Nib held it up, then tucked it into your collection pocket. Your first courier page was ready to read again.

Outside, daylight dappled the dry path. Nib checked that the strap lay flat before lifting the bag. This time he passed through the door without a tug.

Lark opened the route book on a low, level stump. Its first picture showed a fish’s fin beside a fork in the path. She read the next direction aloud. That little word would be your next discovery.

“First stop: Reed Hut,” Lark announced brightly.

“First job: done,” Nib declared proudly.

He looked down at his dependable bag.

“Next job: delivery,” Nib declared eagerly.

With all three invitations safe, you set off together. Behind you, the library door rested open. Ahead, the woodland had readers to find.

The Fan at the Fork

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 2, Episode 2

The library door was behind you now. Nib’s courier bag swung gently against his scarf. Its strap wore the soft pad from your first delivery adventure. Inside, three invitations rested in three separate pockets. Reed Hut, the Mill, and Fern Lodge were still waiting for their letters.

“A dependable bag,” Nib declared proudly. He inspected the doorway tag once more, although the doorway was already far away.

“And a whole woodland ahead,” Lark replied brightly. She opened the route book on a flat stone. Its first direction named the fork beneath the ferns. You followed a dry path, with the bag between your friends.

Nib’s steps grew brisk. He was eager to make the first delivery. Lark paused beside a familiar little word on the first journal page.

“Before our new clue, here is a word we already know,” Lark invited gently. “Read am. Slide its two sounds if you want to.”

At the fork stood two wooden posts. One held a carved fish, with a splendid fin rising from its back. The other carried a small wooden fan. Four broad blades turned whenever the breeze slipped between the trees.

Nib watched the fan turn. He took a step toward its path.

“Very lively directions,” Nib remarked approvingly. “That one must be important.”

“It is moving,” Lark observed thoughtfully. “But movement doesn’t tell us which path the book names.”

She rested the open book on the stone. Both little labels began with the same new letter: f. Lark showed its tall curved line and its short line across.

“Listen to the start of fan,” Lark invited softly. “Touch your top teeth to your lower lip. Let the air flow gently. No hum, and no extra little vowel. Listen to our sound, then find its letter.”

Lark set f beside the a and n you knew. She joined the sounds into fan. Then she changed just the middle letter. The little i from pin made fin.

Nib looked from one label to the other. The beginnings matched. So did the endings. Only the small middle was different.

“I nearly followed the biggest moving thing,” Nib admitted sheepishly.

“We can read the whole word,” Lark reminded him warmly. “Our book names fin. Read both labels, and choose fin for our route.”

The little i settled the question. Lark pointed to the fish’s fin. Its path curved around the fern bank, away from the fan’s short viewing alcove. The crew stayed on dry ground. No one needed to cross the creek here.

Nib gave the fan a courteous bow before leaving.

“Excellent spinning,” Nib told it sincerely. “Different destination.”

At a low resting stone, Lark opened your courier journal. She drew the fish post and left space beneath it for the new letter.

“We can keep our f beside today’s clue,” Lark suggested gently. “Curve over, go down, then add the short line across. Write f on our page.”

Nib lowered the bag onto the dry path before adjusting its strap. One edge had folded over near the soft pad. He smoothed the fold instead of tugging at it.

Lark watched the strap settle flat. The bag still had room for every invitation. A tiny word on the journal’s checking strip ended with t. Nib studied it carefully.

“Our last sound matters, too,” Nib remembered proudly.

“It does,” Lark agreed warmly. “Read the whole little word. Find fit.”

The strap fitted comfortably again. Lark rested while Nib drew a very small story on the spare half of the page. His drawings showed two little mice called Sam and Pip, and a hand fan.

“A story about a fan,” Nib announced contentedly. “A fan that has no opinions about directions.”

Lark showed you the names before the reading. Capital S made the same sound as little s. Capital P made the same sound as little p. You already knew every sound in the words below.

“You can read this part yourself,” Lark invited gently. “Take each sentence in turn. Let your finger follow underneath, and tap a word if you want help.”

The little story had running, resting, and a helpful fan. Nib looked at his picture again. This time the picture could wait. The words told who had done each job.

“Who used the fan in our little story?” Lark asked gently. “You can look back at the sentences.”

Lark tucked the finished fork page into the route book. No new map section appeared. You had something more useful for today: the right path, a comfortable strap, and a clear record of the way you came.

The ferns thinned. Ahead, the creek flashed between pale stones. The path ended on a broad dry bank. A little clay pot stood on a low stump, and a reed-roofed hut waited across the water.

“Our first stop is getting nearer,” Lark murmured eagerly.

Nib counted the bag’s pockets with one careful paw. Three invitations. All safe. None delivered yet.

“First fork found,” Nib declared proudly. “First delivery still to come.”

A breeze stirred the reeds. Behind you, the wooden fan kept turning beside its own path. Ahead, the quiet little pot held the next clue.

On the Wrong Stump

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 2, Episode 3

Several stumps surrounded the creek landing. Nib climbed the tallest and raised one paw in triumph. From there he could see the reeds, the roof of Reed Hut, and very little of the low pot beside the path. All three invitations still rested in his courier bag.

“I am on the top,” Nib announced grandly. “We need the pot,” Lark replied patiently.

Lark opened an earlier journal page on a flat, dry surface. Nib steadied its lower corner. One familiar word waited for another look.

“Try our earlier word before we start,” Lark invited gently. “You can sound it out or ask for help.”

> **fin**

“Here is lowercase o,” Lark explained clearly. “Its short sound begins on and sits in the middle of pot. Listen: /o/. It is different from the short i in pit. Put p and t around each vowel, and hear how the word changes.”

“Join the parts and check the whole meaning,” Lark invited gently. “You can hear a part again whenever you want.”

On a little practice strip, you could try on, pot, top, nod. Lark supplied unfamiliar story names herself. Nib waited while you looked right through each word.

“Our route key names pot,” Lark invited gently. “Read pot and pit, then choose the marker the note actually names.”

A short passage stayed in view. Lark paired each needed capital with its lowercase form and familiar sound before you began, leaving the sentence meanings for you to discover.

“Read the sentences in order,” Lark invited gently. “Let your finger follow if it helps. When you are ready, use the words to answer our question.”

Dan sat on top. Sam did not.

“Who sat on top in that little passage?” Lark asked gently. “Find the name in the first sentence.”

Lark kept the passage open so you could point to the part that helped. Nib listened before adding the picture.

Lark lifted the pot from its low stump. Beneath its base lay a folded crossing note. She read its longer words aloud: the creek handrail needed fastening before the crew crossed. Nib climbed down from his excellent viewing stump. The useful information had been lower than his nose all along. They replaced the pot and walked to the repair shelter.

“Let's keep a written clue,” Lark suggested warmly. “Write o beside our picture. You can look at the example, follow it first, or try your own version. Then reread what you made.”

Lark drew the low pot and its hidden note. Across the creek, Reed Hut waited. The first invitation was still undelivered, but now the crew knew what needed doing before they reached it.

The Kit That Would Not Fit

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 2, Episode 4

The repair shelter had two cupboards. Nib chose an enormous empty cap box, imagining how splendid every tool would look inside it. When he lifted it, its corners hid the handrail note. The actual equipment cupboard was small enough to fit beside his bag.

“It is a capacious cap box,” Nib argued hopefully. “We need a kit,” Lark reminded him warmly.

Lark opened an earlier journal page on a flat, dry surface. Nib steadied its lower corner. One familiar word waited for another look.

“Try our earlier word before we start,” Lark invited gently. “You can sound it out or ask for help.”

on

“Lowercase c and lowercase k can both stand for /k/,” Lark modeled clearly. “Hear the short sound in cap, then kit. No extra vowel after it. We'll practice each letter separately before joining it to the sounds we know.”

“Join the parts and check the whole meaning,” Lark invited gently. “You can hear a part again whenever you want.”

On a little practice strip, you could try cat, cap, cot, kit, kin. Lark supplied unfamiliar story names herself. Nib waited while you looked right through each word.

“Read cap and kit,” Lark encouraged gently. “Which cupboard names the equipment we need?”

A short passage stayed in view. Lark paired each needed capital with its lowercase form and familiar sound before you began, leaving the sentence meanings for you to discover.

“Read the sentences in order,” Lark invited gently. “Let your finger follow if it helps. When you are ready, use the words to answer our question.”

> **Sam can sit on top. Pat can sit on top.**

“Can both friends sit on top, or only one?” Lark asked warmly. “Use both sentences.”

Lark kept the passage open so you could point to the part that helped. Nib listened before adding the picture.

Inside the kit cupboard were a short rope and a fastening hook. Lark flew the light rope across to the fixed far post. Nib fastened the near end and checked the line while the walking boards stayed firmly on their supports. They crossed with the compact kit and all three invitations. The giant empty box stayed where it belonged.

“Let's keep a written clue,” Lark suggested warmly. “Write c and k beside our picture. You can look at the example, follow it first, or try your own version. Then reread what you made.”

Reed Hut's porch was dry under their feet. Behind them the handrail stayed secured. Nib looked down at his small kit with new respect. It had brought exactly enough equipment, with no enormous corners to carry.

The Hat on the Handle

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 2, Episode 5

A hat hung over Reed Hut's door handle. Its brim covered the letter flap and most of the caretaker's hanging notice. The caretaker was working in the reeds, so the first delivery needed to follow the instructions left behind. Nib peered beneath the brim as if it might answer him.

“A hat has taken the postman’s job,” Nib whispered suspiciously. “It is keeping the handle warm,” Lark suggested kindly.

Lark opened an earlier journal page on a flat, dry surface. Nib steadied its lower corner. One familiar word waited for another look.

“Try our earlier word before we start,” Lark invited gently. “You can sound it out or ask for help.”

> **cat**

“Lowercase h starts hat,” Lark modeled softly. “Let your breath flow gently: /h/. No hum. Join h, a, t into hat. Now change the middle vowel for hot. Hear the difference before you read the notice.”

“Join the parts and check the whole meaning,” Lark invited gently. “You can hear a part again whenever you want.”

On a little practice strip, you could try hat, hot, ham, hip, hop. Lark supplied unfamiliar story names herself. Nib waited while you looked right through each word.

“Read hat on the hanging notice,” Lark invited gently. “Which thing has been left over the flap?”

A short passage stayed in view. Lark paired each needed capital with its lowercase form and familiar sound before you began, leaving the sentence meanings for you to discover.

“Read the sentences in order,” Lark invited gently. “Let your finger follow if it helps. When you are ready, use the words to answer our question.”

> **Sam had ham. Pat had hot ham.**

“Whose ham was hot?” Lark asked gently. “Find the extra describing word.”

Lark kept the passage open so you could point to the part that helped. Nib listened before adding the picture.

Nib moved the hat to its proper hook. The flap appeared below it. He lifted the whole courier bag, then remembered its separate pockets. Lark read the destination on the Reed Hut envelope and posted that invitation alone. The caretaker's note promised a reply in this same flap on the return journey. Two invitations remained packed.

“Let's keep a written clue,” Lark suggested warmly. “Write h beside our picture. You can look at the example, follow it first, or try your own version. Then reread what you made.”

Your journal gained its first completed delivery. Lark marked the flap as the place to collect the reply. Then the crew followed the Mill path, leaving the hat on its hook and the invitation safely inside.

The Wet Pen

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 2, Episode 6

A shower reached the Mill route shelter before you did. The old visitor pen lay in a wet patch beside a blurred direction page. Nib tried one careful mark. It spread into an impressive puddle of ink. Later couriers would need a clearer direction than that.

“A very wet pen,” Nib reported gravely. “A dry one would be a splendid improvement,” Lark agreed.

Lark opened an earlier journal page on a flat, dry surface. Nib steadied its lower corner. One familiar word waited for another look.

“Try our earlier word before we start,” Lark invited gently. “You can sound it out or ask for help.”

> **hat**

“Lowercase e makes the short middle sound in pen,” Lark explained clearly. “Listen to pen and pin. Keep p and n in place while the middle changes. The dry pen can write our message; the pin has a different job.”

“Join the parts and check the whole meaning,” Lark invited gently. “You can hear a part again whenever you want.”

On a little practice strip, you could try pen, pet, hen, net, red. Lark supplied unfamiliar story names herself. Nib waited while you looked right through each word.

“Read pen and pin on the kit pockets,” Lark invited gently. “Find what we need for a readable note.”

A short passage stayed in view. Lark paired each needed capital with its lowercase form and familiar sound before you began, leaving the sentence meanings for you to discover.

“Read the sentences in order,” Lark invited gently. “Let your finger follow if it helps. When you are ready, use the words to answer our question.”

Sam met Pat. Pat fed Sam.

“Who fed Sam?” Lark asked gently. “Look at the name that starts the second sentence.”

Lark kept the passage open so you could point to the part that helped. Nib listened before adding the picture.

Nib held a dry backing beneath a fresh page. Lark used the dry pen to draw the next turn beside a red route post. You could add red beneath the picture using familiar sounds and the new e. They hung the note beneath the roof, where the next shower would miss it. The two remaining invitations stayed dry in their pockets.

“Let's keep a written clue,” Lark suggested warmly. “Write red beside our picture. You can look at the example, follow it first, or try your own version. Then reread what you made.”

The wet pen stayed aside to dry. Your working pen returned to the kit. Beyond the shelter, a fallen log lay beside the Mill gate, and the gate would not swing. At least the route to it was clearly recorded now.

The Gate and the Log

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 2, Episode 7

Nib leaned against the fallen log. It did not move. He leaned more grandly. His goggles moved, but the log still did not. The Mill gate caught near its hinge. Lark crouched beside the bottom rail instead of pushing at the largest piece of wood.

“I was moving the large difficulty,” Nib explained breathlessly. “Let us try the small gap,” Lark urged gently.

Lark opened an earlier journal page on a flat, dry surface. Nib steadied its lower corner. One familiar word waited for another look.

“Try our earlier word before we start,” Lark invited gently. “You can sound it out or ask for help.”

> **pen**

“Here g makes the sound at the beginning of gap,” Lark modeled clearly. “Use your voice for the brief /g/, without adding a vowel. Join g, a, p. Other words can give this letter another sound later; today we are using gap and get.”

“Join the parts and check the whole meaning,” Lark invited gently. “You can hear a part again whenever you want.”

On a little practice strip, you could try gap, get, got, dig, tag. Lark supplied unfamiliar story names herself. Nib waited while you looked right through each word.

“Read gap on the repair diagram,” Lark invited softly. “Which small opening does its arrow show beside the hinge?”

A short passage stayed in view. Lark paired each needed capital with its lowercase form and familiar sound before you began, leaving the sentence meanings for you to discover.

“Read the sentences in order,” Lark invited gently. “Let your finger follow if it helps. When you are ready, use the words to answer our question.”

> **Pat got mad. Sam did not get mad.**

“Which friend stayed calm in the little passage?” Lark asked gently. “Read the sentence with not.”

Lark kept the passage open so you could point to the part that helped. Nib listened before adding the picture.

Through the gap, Lark could see a loose branch wedged under the hinge. Nib threaded a short strap around that branch. Together they lifted only the loose piece. The heavy log remained stable on the ground. The gate swung free, and your two undelivered invitations entered the Mill yard without a single log being rolled away.

“Let's keep a written clue,” Lark suggested warmly. “Write gap beside our picture. You can look at the example, follow it first, or try your own version. Then reread what you made.”

Lark drew the small branch beside the large log. The open gate was the result of moving the right thing. Ahead, round containers crowded the Mill delivery ledge. Nib kept the envelope in his bag while they looked for a flat place.

The Little Ledge

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 2, Episode 8

The Mill's delivery ledge was full of round tins. Nib balanced an invitation on top. It slid, glided down a curved lid, and landed neatly in his lap. He looked pleased to have caught it and less pleased to have become the delivery shelf.

“A letter in my lap,” Nib observed ruefully. “A ledge with a lip,” Lark replied with relief.

Lark opened an earlier journal page on a flat, dry surface. Nib steadied its lower corner. One familiar word waited for another look.

“Try our earlier word before we start,” Lark invited gently. “You can sound it out or ask for help.”

gap

“Lowercase l begins lip,” Lark explained softly. “Touch your tongue just behind your top teeth and let your voice flow: /l/. Don't add an extra vowel. Join l, i, p. On this diagram, lip means the little raised edge that stops a letter sliding off.”

“Join the parts and check the whole meaning,” Lark invited gently. “You can hear a part again whenever you want.”

On a little practice strip, you could try lip, leg, log, lap, let. Lark supplied unfamiliar story names herself. Nib waited while you looked right through each word.

“Find lip on the shelf sketch,” Lark invited gently. “Which edge could help our envelope stay flat?”

A short passage stayed in view. Lark paired each needed capital with its lowercase form and familiar sound before you began, leaving the sentence meanings for you to discover.

“Read the sentences in order,” Lark invited gently. “Let your finger follow if it helps. When you are ready, use the words to answer our question.”

> **Sam let Pat hop. Pat did hop.**

“Who did the hopping?” Lark asked gently. “Use the second sentence to check.”

Lark kept the passage open so you could point to the part that helped. Nib listened before adding the picture.

One empty tray covered a lower flat space behind the retaining lip. Nib shifted that tray to an unused support and left the working tins alone. The envelope now had somewhere level to wait. Before posting it, Lark checked the collection diagram. A marked reply box beneath the bench still needed identifying.

“Let's keep a written clue,” Lark suggested warmly. “Write l beside our picture. You can look at the example, follow it first, or try your own version. Then reread what you made.”

Your journal showed the ledge with its useful lip. The Mill invitation remained retrievable beside the crew, and the Fern Lodge envelope stayed packed. A better shelf was ready; the right box was next.

The Box Beneath the Bench

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 2, Episode 9

Two boxes stood beneath the Mill bench. One was impressively large. The other had an ordinary-sized lid. Nib leaned toward the large box before reading either label. Lark set the invitation on the prepared ledge, where it could wait safely.

“Big box, big importance,” Nib announced confidently. “Small word, exact place,” Lark answered gently.

Lark opened an earlier journal page on a flat, dry surface. Nib steadied its lower corner. One familiar word waited for another look.

“Try our earlier word before we start,” Lark invited gently. “You can sound it out or ask for help.”

> **lip**

“Lowercase b begins bag,” Lark modeled clearly. “A brief voiced /b/, without an extra vowel. Look at b beside d: b has its tall stem first, with the round part on the right. Join b, i, n to read bin.”

“Join the parts and check the whole meaning,” Lark invited gently. “You can hear a part again whenever you want.”

On a little practice strip, you could try bag, bed, big, bin, cob. Lark supplied unfamiliar story names herself. Nib waited while you looked right through each word.

“Read bin and kit on these boxes,” Lark invited gently. “Which word names our letter box?”

A short passage stayed in view. Lark paired each needed capital with its lowercase form and familiar sound before you began, leaving the sentence meanings for you to discover.

“Read the sentences in order,” Lark invited gently. “Let your finger follow if it helps. When you are ready, use the words to answer our question.”

> **Bob hid. Sam did not.**

“Who hid?” Lark asked softly. “Which sentence gives you that information?”

Lark kept the passage open so you could point to the part that helped. Nib listened before adding the picture.

The correct box was the letter bin, whatever its size. Nib posted the Mill invitation there. Lark read the collection card and drew the same bin on your return-route page. The Mill reply would be left here later. Reed Hut and the Mill now had their invitations. Only Fern Lodge's envelope remained in the courier bag.

“Let's keep a written clue,” Lark suggested warmly. “Write b beside our picture. You can look at the example, follow it first, or try your own version. Then reread what you made.”

Lark recorded the second delivery once. Nib closed the empty Mill pocket and lifted the bag. On the next path, a shallow puddle brushed its lower strap. The last invitation was dry, but the bag needed somewhere better to rest.

The Cup in the Mud

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 2, Episode 10

The lower strap dipped into muddy water while Nib checked the route book. Fern Lodge's envelope stayed dry inside its protective folio. Nib began to drag the bag away, then stopped when the wet strap pulled against its base. Lark pointed to a low dry stump nearby.

“My bag has dipped a toe in,” Nib remarked anxiously. “Let us lift the toe, not tip the bag,” Lark urged calmly.

Lark opened an earlier journal page on a flat, dry surface. Nib steadied its lower corner. One familiar word waited for another look.

“Try our earlier word before we start,” Lark invited gently. “You can sound it out or ask for help.”

> **bag**

“Lowercase u has the short sound in cup and mud,” Lark modeled clearly. “Listen to cup and cap. The outside sounds stay the same while the middle changes. We've now met five short vowel sounds; we can listen for the one each word actually needs.”

“Join the parts and check the whole meaning,” Lark invited gently. “You can hear a part again whenever you want.”

On a little practice strip, you could try cup, cut, mud, sun, tub. Lark supplied unfamiliar story names herself. Nib waited while you looked right through each word.

“Read cup and cap in the kit,” Lark invited calmly. “Which one can scoop a little surface water away?”

A short passage stayed in view. Lark paired each needed capital with its lowercase form and familiar sound before you began, leaving the sentence meanings for you to discover.

“Read the sentences in order,” Lark invited gently. “Let your finger follow if it helps. When you are ready, use the words to answer our question.”

> **Sam dug. Pat sat in mud.**

“Who sat in mud?” Lark asked gently. “What did the other friend do?”

Lark kept the passage open so you could point to the part that helped. Nib listened before adding the picture.

Nib used the cup beside the strap while Lark brought the bag's handle onto its lifting hook. Together they lifted the bag clear and settled it on the stump without tipping its contents. Nib checked all three pockets. The only remaining invitation was dry. He clipped the muddy cup outside the protected message pocket before setting off again.

“Let's keep a written clue,” Lark suggested warmly. “Write u beside our picture. You can look at the example, follow it first, or try your own version. Then reread what you made.”

Your journal showed the bag lifted clear of the puddle. Beyond the muddy patch, sunlight warmed the Fern Lodge path. A sheltered rest would keep the crew comfortable before the final outward delivery.

The Shade That Wandered

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 2, Episode 11

Nib put the umbrella beside a resting board. Its shade fell beautifully over the grass. Unfortunately, the bag was on the board. When Nib moved the bag into the shade, he sat down in the sunny place it had left. Lark watched the patch of light with a thoughtful smile.

“The shade wandered,” Nib complained mildly. “The umbrella stayed where we put it,” Lark observed with amusement.

Lark opened an earlier journal page on a flat, dry surface. Nib steadied its lower corner. One familiar word waited for another look.

“Try our earlier word before we start,” Lark invited gently. “You can sound it out or ask for help.”

> **cup**

“Lowercase w begins wet,” Lark modeled clearly. “Round your lips, then move smoothly into the next sound: /w/. Join w, e, t. Compare wet with the sun label on our resting-place note. The words tell us something about each place.”

“Join the parts and check the whole meaning,” Lark invited gently. “You can hear a part again whenever you want.”

On a little practice strip, you could try web, wet, win, wag. Lark supplied unfamiliar story names herself. Nib waited while you looked right through each word.

“Read wet and sun,” Lark invited gently. “Which place is dry, and what does it still need for a comfortable rest?”

A short passage stayed in view. Lark paired each needed capital with its lowercase form and familiar sound before you began, leaving the sentence meanings for you to discover.

“Read the sentences in order,” Lark invited gently. “Let your finger follow if it helps. When you are ready, use the words to answer our question.”

> **Sam got wet. Pat did not get wet.**

“Which friend stayed dry?” Lark asked gently. “Find the word that changes what happened.”

Lark kept the passage open so you could point to the part that helped. Nib listened before adding the picture.

Nib set the bag on the dry board. Lark moved the umbrella's support so its shade covered that board, then anchored its base. Nobody disturbed the spider web beside the shelter. Now the dry resting place was shaded as well. The crew sat together, with Fern Lodge's invitation protected beside them.

“Let's keep a written clue,” Lark suggested warmly. “Write w beside our picture. You can look at the example, follow it first, or try your own version. Then reread what you made.”

After the rest, Fern Lodge's porch was close enough to see. Lark packed the umbrella and checked the route note. A folded receiving sack hung beside the doorway, ready for the last invitation.

Pack the Right Sack

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 2, Episode 12

At Fern Lodge, Nib wrapped the final invitation in spare cloth. Then he added another piece, and another, until the destination mark vanished. The caretaker's receiving instructions were fixed beside a folded sack. Lark looked from the neat instruction to the enormous anonymous bundle.

“Packed beyond all recognition,” Nib reported proudly. “Recognition is part of the job,” Lark reminded him kindly.

Lark opened an earlier journal page on a flat, dry surface. Nib steadied its lower corner. One familiar word waited for another look.

“Try our earlier word before we start,” Lark invited gently. “You can sound it out or ask for help.”

> **web**

“Here c and k work together for one /k/ sound,” Lark explained clearly. “Read pack, then sack. Don't sound the pair twice. Capital P has the same beginning sound as little p. In Pack it, two words give us one useful instruction.”

“Join the parts and check the whole meaning,” Lark invited gently. “You can hear a part again whenever you want.”

On a little practice strip, you could try pack, sack, back, sock. Lark supplied unfamiliar story names herself. Nib waited while you looked right through each word.

“Read Pack it,” Lark invited warmly. “Which protection keeps the envelope safe while leaving its destination visible?”

A short passage stayed in view. Lark paired each needed capital with its lowercase form and familiar sound before you began, leaving the sentence meanings for you to discover.

“Read the sentences in order,” Lark invited gently. “Let your finger follow if it helps. When you are ready, use the words to answer our question.”

Sam can pack. Pat can pack.

“Can both friends pack?” Lark asked gently. “Check that each sentence tells us so.”

Lark kept the passage open so you could point to the part that helped. Nib listened before adding the picture.

Nib removed the extra wrapping. The protective folio fitted into the intended sack without hiding the destination. Lark posted the Fern Lodge invitation through the receiving flap. The caretaker's note promised a reply at the same sack hook. All three outward invitations had reached their destinations; the return circuit could begin.

“Let's keep a written clue,” Lark suggested warmly. “Write pack beside our picture. You can look at the example, follow it first, or try your own version. Then reread what you made.”

Lark drew the sack hook as your third reply-collection place. Nib's three delivery pockets were empty for a good reason. A small signal bell beside the porch made only a muffled hiss when its cord moved.

The Bell That Hissed

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 2, Episode 13

Fern Lodge's reply sack was waiting. Its signal bell was not doing nearly as well. A loose cloth edge lay against the clapper. Nib blew at it with a magnificent puff, and the bell answered with the faintest possible hiss. Lark found the stand's short instruction.

“A very quiet bell,” Nib whispered suspiciously. “A bell wearing a scarf,” Lark replied gently.

Lark opened an earlier journal page on a flat, dry surface. Nib steadied its lower corner. One familiar word waited for another look.

“Try our earlier word before we start,” Lark invited gently. “You can sound it out or ask for help.”

> **pack**

“In bell and fill, the two l letters share one /l/ sound,” Lark explained clearly. “Puff ends with one /f/ written ff. Hiss ends with one /s/ written ss. We still blend the sounds once each; extra letters don't ask for extra little vowels.”

“Join the parts and check the whole meaning,” Lark invited gently. “You can hear a part again whenever you want.”

On a little practice strip, you could try puff, fill, bell, hiss. Lark supplied unfamiliar story names herself. Nib waited while you looked right through each word.

“Read bell on the stand note,” Lark invited gently. “Which part needs room to move?”

A short passage stayed in view. Lark paired each needed capital with its lowercase form and familiar sound before you began, leaving the sentence meanings for you to discover.

“Read the sentences in order,” Lark invited gently. “Let your finger follow if it helps. When you are ready, use the words to answer our question.”

> **Sam can fill. Pat can puff.**

“Which friend can puff?” Lark asked warmly. “Look at the word after can in each sentence.”

Lark kept the passage open so you could point to the part that helped. Nib listened before adding the picture.

Nib lifted the loose cloth and fixed it clear of the clapper. The bell rang once. They collected Fern Lodge's reply from the agreed hook. On the return path they used their own notes: the Mill reply waited in its letter bin, and Reed Hut's reply waited in its flap. Three replies settled into three separate bag pockets.

“Let's keep a written clue,” Lark suggested warmly. “Write bell beside our picture. You can look at the example, follow it first, or try your own version. Then reread what you made.”

The cloth stayed clear and the bell stayed useful. With every invitation delivered and every reply collected, the crew followed the familiar dry path back to camp. Nothing was still waiting at an unvisited stop.

The First Post Round

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 2, Episode 14

At camp, Nib lifted a flag above the new post rack. Lark laid the three replies beneath it. Before they celebrated, each reply needed its destination beside it, and the route book needed the details another courier would actually use. The flag could wait while the record became clear.

“Delivered. Returned. Remembered,” Nib declared with satisfaction. “Ready for someone else to follow,” Lark added warmly.

Lark opened an earlier journal page on a flat, dry surface. Nib steadied its lower corner. One familiar word waited for another look.

“Try our earlier word before we start,” Lark invited gently. “You can sound it out or ask for help.”

> **puff**

“In stamp, keep the beginning sounds close: /s/, /t/,” Lark modeled clearly. “Don't slip a vowel between them. Join the rest, then read step the same way. All the familiar sounds keep their jobs when consonants stand side by side.”

“Join the parts and check the whole meaning,” Lark invited gently. “You can hear a part again whenever you want.”

On a little practice strip, you could try stamp, tent, flag, step. Lark supplied unfamiliar story names herself. Nib waited while you looked right through each word.

“Read the rack labels and our return notes,” Lark invited warmly. “Which destination belongs with each reply?”

A short passage stayed in view. Lark paired each needed capital with its lowercase form and familiar sound before you began, leaving the sentence meanings for you to discover.

“Read the sentences in order,” Lark invited gently. “Let your finger follow if it helps. When you are ready, use the words to answer our question.”

> **Sam can stamp. Pat can step.**

“Who can stamp?” Lark asked gently. “Which friend has the other job?”

Lark kept the passage open so you could point to the part that helped. Nib listened before adding the picture.

Lark supplied the place names while you checked the short labels and route pictures. Reed Hut's flap, the Mill bin, and Fern Lodge's sack hook matched the three pockets. Nib set the flag above a rack that now told the whole story. Neighbors arrived to use the library, and a little post horn joined your collection.

“Let's keep a written clue,” Lark suggested warmly. “Write stamp beside our picture. You can look at the example, follow it first, or try your own version. Then reread what you made.”

Nib gave the horn one cheerful note. Lark bound fourteen journal chapters into Through the Woods. The post circuit was working: three invitations out, three replies home. One reply invited a later visit to Lookout Hill. Tonight, the second book stood finished beside the first.